

The Hedge-Law Realm

A Viterran Expansion for Fate's Edge

Set down by Dusana of the Raven Road, under a borrowed lamp in

The ink is gall and the ash of a burned writ. The binding is leather from a

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Preface: The Queen's Peace

The law is not a sword. It is a scale. A sword can be stolen; a scale only tilts.

— Queen Veralyn Everblood, from her first address to the Parlement

Viterra is not a land of crumbling ruins or haunted moors. It is a land of hedgerows and courthouses, of ancient customs written in margins, of disputes settled by gavel and precedent rather than by blade. The Queen's Peace is not a promise—it is a contract, renewed each morning by every magistrate, every justicar, every clerk who opens a ledger.

After the succession wars that bled the eastern marches for a generation, Queen Veralyn Everblood sits on a throne still warm from her rivals' blood. She is young, unmarried, and surrounded by counselors who mistake caution for loyalty. Her reign is defined by three pressures:

- The need to rebuild law where war left only custom.
- The presence of turncloak nobles who switched sides multiple times during the wars and now demand pardon.
- The quiet power of the Justicars—magistrates who can travel anywhere, hear any case, and speak with the Queen's own voice.

This expansion provides the tools to play in Viterra: legal duels, oath-courts, hedge-law, and the politics of a realm that has learned, at great cost, that justice is the only

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thing that holds a kingdom together when armies have gone home.

Chapter 1

The Pillars of Viterran Law

Viterran law is not written in a single codex. It lives in four sources, each with its own weight.

1.1 The Queen's Word

The monarch may issue decrees, but a decree that contradicts the Codex of Precedents is null unless confirmed by the Parlement. Queen Veralyn has issued only seven decrees in five years; her predecessor issued forty in a single session.

A royal decree carries the weight of the crown's authority. To defy it is treason. But the Queen herself may be petitioned to set aside a decree that causes manifest harm—a check on absolute power that has not been used in living memory.

1.2 The Codex of Precedents

A massive book, kept in the White Hall under lock and witness, recording every judgment of the Queen's Justicars for four centuries. When a new case arises, the first question is always: "What does the Codex say?" If no precedent

exists, the Justicar creates one—and the next Justicar must follow it.

The Codex is not infallible. Pages have been lost to fire, water, and deliberate excision. Some precedents contradict one another; older clerks whisper that the Codex sometimes changes overnight, a new clause appearing in a margin as if written by a ghost.

Strings (Viterran Law)

- Precedent Citation – Reroll a failed Insight roll related to law or custom.
- Codex Page – A copied folio; once per session, reduce DV by 1 on a legal argument.

1.3 The Hedge-Law

The unwritten customs of villages and rural manors. A hedge-court has no gavel, only a stool and a witness. Its judgments are binding only on those who consent—but refusal to consent is itself a mark against one's reputation. Hedge-law covers boundary stones, water rights, grazing rotations, and the proper distance between beehives.

Hedge-courts are held under ancient oaks or at crossroads. The judge is often the oldest person present, or the one with the most even temper. Verdicts are pragmatic: a stolen pig is replaced; a broken fence is mended by the one who broke it; a blood-feud is settled by a marriage.

Strings (Hedge-Law)

- Boundary Stone – Declare a disputed line once; the hedge-court will honor your claim for a season.
- Hedge Writ – Safe passage through rural lands; no tolls, no questions.

1.4 The Right of Acknowledgment

The newest pillar, added by Queen Veralyn's own hand after the trial of Baron Aldric the Turncloak. It permits any child who was not ransomed, not visited, or not named in a will to demand that a parent speak one truth aloud under witness.

The truth need not be kind. It need only be honest.

Once spoken, the debt is considered paid in full. The parent cannot be compelled again. The child may walk away—or stay. The law does not care.

Mechanically, invoking the Right of Acknowledgment is a social action (Presence + Sway or Command) against the parent's Resolve. On a hit, the parent speaks a true answer to one question. On a critical, the answer must be complete and without evasion. The parent may refuse, but refusal is an admission of guilt in the court of public reputation—they become *anima non grata*, and no lawful burial ground will accept their body.

Chapter 2

Factions of Viterra

2.1 The Queen's Justicars

A small order of traveling magistrates, each bearing a silver gavel and a sealed writ. A Justicar may hear any case, anywhere, and her judgment is final unless overturned by the Queen herself. There are only twelve Justicars in all of Viterra. They are feared, respected, and occasionally murdered.

Strings

- Gavel token (force a parley under witness)
- Justicar's seal (DV -1 for legal negotiations)
- Precedent citation (reroll a failed Insight roll related to law)

2.2 The Hedge-Courts

Local assemblies of elders, millers, and retired soldiers who settle disputes without reference to the Codex. Their judgments are pragmatic, swift, and often brutal. A hedge-court can outlaw a person from a village—a sentence of slow starvation.

Strings

- Boundary stone (declare a disputed line once)
- Hedge writ (safe passage through rural lands)
- Goose feather (one use to call a moot)

2.3 The Turncloak Nobility

Nobles who changed sides during the succession wars. Some did so out of opportunity; others out of fear. Queen Veralyn has pardoned most but forgotten none. Their estates are intact, but their honor is stained. Many seek redemption through service—or revenge through conspiracy.

Strings

- Pardon letter (reduces Exposure by 2 in Viterra)
- Oath of fealty (once/arc, call on a turncloak for aid, but mark a Debt to them)
- Blood-silver receipt (proof of payment for a past betrayal)

2.4 The Parlement of Viterra

An assembly of nobles, bishops, and guildmasters that meets twice a year to advise the Queen and approve taxes. The Parlement has no power to make law, but it can refuse to fund the Queen's projects. Veralyn has learned to charm, bribe, and threaten them by turns.

Strings

- Proxy vote (once/session, sway a Parlement decision)
- Tax receipt (reduces Supply cost by 1 in Viteran markets)
- Censure motion (public shaming of an enemy)

Chapter 3

New Talents: The Justicar's Path

For characters who walk the road of law, oath, and judgment. These talents are available to any class, but they resonate most strongly with Runekeepers of Mykkiel or The Witness.

3.1 Foundation Talents (2–4 XP)

Cite Precedent (2 XP)

Once per session, you may declare that a past judgment covers the current situation. Roll Wits + Lore (DV 3). On a hit, gain +1 die on your next legal or social roll. On a miss, the precedent is contested—GM gains 1 SB.

Gavel's Authority (4 XP)

You carry a small gavel (or a symbolic equivalent). When you strike it against a hard surface and state a judgment, hostile NPCs within Near range must test Resolve (DV 4) or hesitate for one exchange. Usable once per scene.

3.2 Advanced Talents (6–8 XP)

Right of Acknowledgment (6 XP)

Requirement: You have witnessed an injustice involving kin or oath. Once per arc, you may demand that an NPC speak one true answer to a question of your choice. The NPC may refuse, but refusal forfeits all legal protections (they become *anima non grata* in Viterran territory). The truth need not be complete, but it must not be a lie.

Justicar's Immunity (8 XP)

You have been granted the Queen's own seal. You cannot be arrested or detained by any lesser authority in Viterra. However, abuse of this immunity (committing a crime in plain sight) will cause the seal to crack—lose this talent until you undergo a ritual of purification (a downtime project).

Chapter 4

Patrons of the Viterran Courts

4.1 The Witness (Viterran Variant)

Here, The Witness does not reveal hidden truths—it attests to sworn testimony. Its shrines are courthouses; its rites are oaths spoken under a single lamp.

Low Rite — Testimony (4 XP)

When you repeat a statement you heard under oath, you may roll Presence + Investigation (DV 3). On a hit, you know whether the statement was false. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite — Unbreakable Vow (8 XP)

You and a willing partner swear an oath before witnesses. Until the oath is fulfilled, both gain +1 die to any action that serves it. Breaking the oath causes 2 Harm (Spirit). (Mark +2 Obligation)

4.2 Mykkiel (Judge of the Scar)

Mykkiel's Viterran face is that of a circuit judge, riding from town to town, carrying a ledger of unpaid debts. His

followers are Justicars who have lost their faith in mercy but not in order.

Low Rite — Summons (4 XP)

Name a person within Far range. They hear your voice as if you stood beside them. They are not compelled to obey, but they know the message is legal. (Mark +1 Fatigue)

Standard Rite — Attachment (8 XP)

Touch an object or person. For one day, any attempt to move them from their current location suffers +1 DV. (Mark +2 Obligation)

4.3 The Queen (Mortal Patron)

Queen Veralyn herself can serve as a Patron for those sworn directly to her service. Her Rites are not magical—they are legal and social permissions.

Low Rite — Royal Favor (4 XP)

Present a token with the Queen's seal. For one scene, any Viterran official treats you as if you were a royal messenger. (Mark +1 Exposure – the Queen's enemies take note)

Standard Rite — Pardon (8 XP)

Forgive one crime committed by another person, as long as that crime did not harm the Queen's interests. The pardon is legally binding. (Mark +2 Obligation to the Queen; she may call on you later)

Chapter 5

The Justicar's Judgment

The tale of Baron Aldric the Turncloak, set down by Dusana of the Raven Road after a cup of small beer in a Viterran hedge-court. The ink is gall and the memory of a father's silence.

Prologue – The Cantor's Vigil

The bells of Rouen are muffled today, wrapped in felt so that their resonance does not disturb the dead that lie beneath the Chapel of the Silent Stair. Alain, his temples crowned with the soft down that marks the Corruption of his patron, stands before the ancient stone, the silver ring on his thumb cracked like a fault line in ice. He presses it, feels the pulse of old bone, and begins the *Planctus Armatus*—the Lament for the Armored—a chant that remembers Sir Corin, the knight who once unbuckled his gorget to hear a thief's voice and was undone by the mercy he offered.

The song is not for the knight's death. It is for the moment before—when the armor opens and the man inside reaches out.

The Orchard

The province-war wind carried ash and the sour scent of burnt orchard trees. Sir Corin, his mail still slick with the mud of BlackFord, rode through a haze of gray, the weight of twenty years of service pressing against his shoulders like a second skin. He halted beside a smoldering copse where a boy of twelve knelt over the corpse of a cook, his small fingers working a tarnished ring from the dead man's thumb.

The boy had not eaten in two days; his hollow cheeks and the tremor in his hands spoke of a hunger that made the stolen ring seem a lifeline. He hummed a fragment of a lullaby, the tune uneven as dough under a novice's hands. He looked up, eyes wide, and the ring slipped free with a soft clink.

"Stand," Corin commanded, his voice hoarse from days without water.

The boy obeyed, his shoulders trembling. The cook's apron, stained with flour, lay abandoned beside the body, a mute testament to the night the cook had fed a starving garrison.

"I should hang you," Corin said, meaning it. He had hanged deserters, looters, men who broke the chivalric code that was the only law left in the fractured duchies.

Instead of begging, the boy began to sing—the Old Vhasian Ballad that would later echo in Alain's own voice.

 "Forget-me-not,"
 The proud knight said,
 Dressed and ready for war.
 His lady kissed him through her tears,
 Fearing to see him no more.

 Down by the river, where the purple flowers
 grow,

He held her close and whispered his love,
But armed and armored, he felt not her touch—
The silk of her delicate glove.

She wept. He rose, as if to leave,
But turned for the flowers instead.
Overreaching, he tumbled down,
And as he sank, he said,
“Forget-me-not.”

Corin listened, the weight of his armor suddenly apparent—not just steel, but the habit of keeping the world at arm’s length. He realized he had not seen his own face unhelmed for months; he could no longer picture his wife’s eyes, only the shape of her letters read by lantern-light.

“Who taught you that?” he asked, the edge of the judge softened.

“The cook,” the boy replied, gesturing to the corpse. “He was kind. He taught me to knead, and he taught me the song. Said it was about the weight of things we choose to carry.”

Corin loosened the twine that bound the boy’s wrist—just enough to let the blood flow, not enough to free him.

“Walk,” he said. “And sing if you must. The road to Rouen is long, and the armor grows heavier with every mile.”

Unbuckling

Rouen’s citadel stood stubborn against the invading tide, but the lower town was a maze of shattered stalls and smoldering rag-piles. Corin had brought the boy—now calling himself Alain—to the empty courthouse, intending to deliver him to justice, only to find the magistrate fled and the seals broken.

The boy watched Corin's face tighten as he read the writ of absence. "There is no law," he whispered. "Only the armor. Only the song."

Corin drew his dagger, the blade catching the wan light. Alain did not flinch. With a swift motion, Corin cut the twine and, in the same breath, unbuckled the gauntlet on his right hand. The metal fell away with a soft clang, revealing a scarred palm that had never known the touch of a child's skin.

"Stay," Corin said, his voice low. "Help me hold the walls. Help me remember what the armor is for."

Alain stayed. He fetched water from the well, his small hands cupping the lukewarm liquid, and carried it to the parapet where a wounded militiaman lay, his thigh pierced by a stray bolt. As Alain knelt, the water spilling over the man's bandages, Corin watched the boy's earnestness and felt something inside him shift—a loosening of the rigid code he had clung to like a second skin.

The Second Unbuckling

The siege entered its seventh day. Fire-spitting siege engines hurled molten projectiles into the city; the sky was a churning mass of smoke and ember. Alain, his throat raw from singing, slipped away from the clamor and found a narrow alley where a child—no older than five—lay cradled in a heap of soot-blackened blankets, breath shallow, cheeks streaked with ash.

He lifted the child, feeling the fragile rise and fall of a tiny chest against his forearm. The boy's eyes fluttered open, wide and terrified, seeking refuge in the stranger's face.

Just then, a timber beam, weakened by the inferno, groaned and began to fall toward the alley. Corin, his visor half-lifted,

appeared from the smoke, his gauntleted hand gripping the child's small wrist for a heartbeat before he shoved the boy behind a shattered wall and threw his own body across the path of the falling timber.

The impact sent a shock of pain through his spine, but his armor held. As the beam crashed, Corin's helm was jarred loose; he reached up, unbuckling the chin strap and letting the heavy helm fall to the cobbles. For the first time in years, his face was exposed—sweat-slick, eyes dark as forged iron, lips parted in a silent gasp.

He looked down at the child, whose small hand clutched the edge of his breastplate. In that gaze passed an unspoken apology: they would not fight side-by-side, but they shared the same sorrow, the same fragile humanity buried beneath steel.

When the beam finally settled, Corin rose, the helm still at his feet, and gathered the child into his arms. He carried the boy toward the chapel, the only refuge still standing amidst the rain of arrows, his steps heavy not just from the weight of his plate but from the weight of the choice he had just made—to see, to protect, to be vulnerable.

Lady Isolde's Reckoning

The southern gate gave way with a shuddering groan; the invading host poured into the streets like a black tide. Amid the chaos, a grim procession emerged from the ruined square: Corin's body, still encased in his battered plate, laid upon a makeshift stretcher hauled by two exhausted soldiers.

Before the stretcher, Lady Isolde of the Western March halted, her sable cloak heavy with the scent of pine and iron. Her gloved hand rested lightly on the breastplate where the insignia of the Order of the Iron Gorget was

still faintly visible beneath the scorch. Her eyes, usually sharp as a hawk's talon, were lowered—not in grief but in calculation.

“A ransom would have solved this,” Lady Isolde said, her voice flat as steel. “We could have taken a price and avoided the extra loss.”

She paused, the wind tugging at the fur lining of her cloak, and added, quieter but no less cold,

“I have taken a hundred prices. This one tastes of nothing.”

Around her, the provincial infantry lowered their weapons; the clang of steel fell silent as the reality of the cost settled over the courtyard. Lord Merrick of the Black Vale, who had ordered the sack, watched the scene with a grimace—aware that the price of victory had already been paid in blood, not gold.

Alain knelt beside the stretcher, his feathers ruffling with each gust that carried ash and sorrow alike. He pressed his lips to the cold steel of Corin's breastplate and sang the opening verses of the *Planctus Armatus*, the lament that would become the very soul of the stave. As his voice rose, raw and trembling, over the ruined chapel's cracked arches, he lifted his hand and, with a reverent tenderness, unbuckled the gorget that guarded Corin's throat. The steel fell away with a barely audible sigh, exposing the pale line of the knight's neck to the wind and to the song.

The soldiers who had come to loot paused, their swords trembling in their hands, as they wove the image of a knight who chose mercy over steel.

When the final note fell, the chapel's roof shuddered and a fire-kissed collapse began. Flames licked the rafters, and the wind seemed to echo the boy's forgotten ballad,

“Forget-me-not,” as the stone walls crumbled around them.

Thus Sir Corin was carried out, his body a monument to both his courage and his vulnerability, while the conquering lord and lady stood on the threshold of the ruined chapel—recognizing, in their own cold way, that even the most practiced chivalry could not mask the brutal reality of war.

Epilogue – Forty Years Later

Now, forty years later, Alain sings in the rebuilt chapel. The Province Wars are officially over, though the duchies still raid one another and the Crown remains more theory than practice. Rouen is prosperous; jousts have returned to the fields beyond the walls. Knights wear armor polished like mirrors and tilt for the favor of ladies whose names they remember, because peace allows memory.

Alain knows—knows in his altered flesh, in the feathers that shed when he hits the high notes, in the shadow that moves a half-step behind him when the moon is full—that the disconnect remains. Knights buckle their gorgets tight. Chivalry is performance. Mercy is scripted. Beneath the jousts and the romance, the old fractures wait, breathing in their iron shells.

He sings the *Planctus Armatus*. The congregation weeps, not for Corin—who is forty years dead—but for the beauty of the voice. They do not hear the warning. They do not know that Alain sings not for the past but for the future, for the moment when the armor must open again or shatter.

The song ends. Alain touches the cracked ring on his thumb. It pulses. The peace is old. The armor is polished. Yet beneath the prosperity he can hear the creak of metal tightening, the snap of buckles being secured, the silence of hearts choosing protection over connection.

He bows. He leaves. His shadow follows a half-step behind.

This chronicle was compiled from the Cantor's testimony, from the armorer's marks on Corin's breastplate (now in the Rouen museum), and from the Ethorian ballads of the marches, which remember what the cantons forget.

— Dusana of the Raven Road, Rouen, 847 AR

Chapter 6

Adventure Seeds

1. The Unfinished Testament. A dying noble calls for a Justicar to witness his will. The will disinherits his eldest son in favor of a bastard daughter who was never ransomed from captivity. The son hires thugs to intercept the Justicar. The party must deliver her to the bedside before the old man dies.
2. Hedge-Court at Dusk. A village accuses a turncloak knight of stealing a boundary stone. The knight claims the stone was always on his land. The party must survey the hedge, interview the oldest residents, and render a verdict that will not start a blood-feud.
3. The Turncloak's Daughter. A Vhasian baron's daughter, now living in Viterra, petitions for the Right of Acknowledgment against her father's estate. The father is dead, but his executors refuse to release her inheritance. The party must find a witness who heard the father speak a damning truth—or forge a confession that the hedge-court will accept.
4. The Codex Theft. A page from the Codex of Precedents has been stolen—a page that would decide a pending lawsuit between two powerful houses. The party must track the thief through the underworld of legal scribes and forgers before the case is dismissed for lack of precedent.

5. The Queen's Suitors. Queen Veralyn has announced she will consider marriage offers. Every noble house in Viterra sends a champion to court her. The party is hired by a minor house to sabotage the other suitors—legally, of course. No poison. No daggers. Just clever readings of dowry law, ambush by precedent, and a well-timed Right of Acknowledgment.

Chapter 7

GM Toolkit: Clocks and Fronts

7.1 Sample Clocks

Clock	Purpose	Advance / Retreat
The Queen's Patience [6]	How long the crown tolerates noble infighting	Advance when parties flout Justicar rulings; retreat when a major case is settled cleanly
Hedge-Law Fracture [4]	Local customs breaking down under pressure	Advance when a hedge-court's verdict is ignored; retreat when a respected elder restores peace
Turncloak Conspiracy [8]	A plot among pardoned nobles to reclaim lost lands	Advance when the party ignores rumors or protects a turncloak; retreat when a conspirator is exposed
Codex Decay [6]	The Codex losing authority as precedents contradict	Advance when contradictory rulings are issued; retreat when a Justicar reconciles two precedents

7.2 Sample Front: The Succession Crisis

Impulse: The Queen has no heir. Her marriage negotiations have stalled. The turncloak nobility smell blood.

Grim Portents:

- A hedge-court declares a local lord has the "ancient right" to name the next Queen.
- The Parlement refuses to fund the Justicars, leaving a key case unheard.
- A turncloak knight invokes the Right of Acknowledgment against the Queen herself, demanding she name her father's true heir.

Clocks:

- Throne Vacancy [8] – When full, a claimant marches on the White Hall.
- Justicar Defection [4] – When full, one of the twelve Justicars declares for a rival.
- People's Petition [6] – When full, a hedge-court of commoners issues a binding judgment on the succession, overriding noble law.

Chapter 8

Colophon

This expansion was written in a Viterran hedge-court, on paper that had been used to wrap cheese. The ink is gall and the ash of a burned writ. The binding is leather from a debtor's cow.

The Queen's Justicar Cass Venn died in her sleep seven years after the trial of Baron Aldric. Her gavel is kept in the White Hall, next to the Codex of Precedents. Children who visit the Hall are told to touch it for luck. They do.

Ser Roran served the Queen for thirty years. He never married. He never took a squire. He wore the silver gauntlet until the day he died, and it was buried with him. The hedge-knight who ransomed him has no grave—his body was never found. But Roran paid his widow every year on the anniversary of the ransom, in full, with interest.

The road to Viterra is straight, the hedges are trimmed, and the law is patient.

The ink is dry. The gavel is still.